

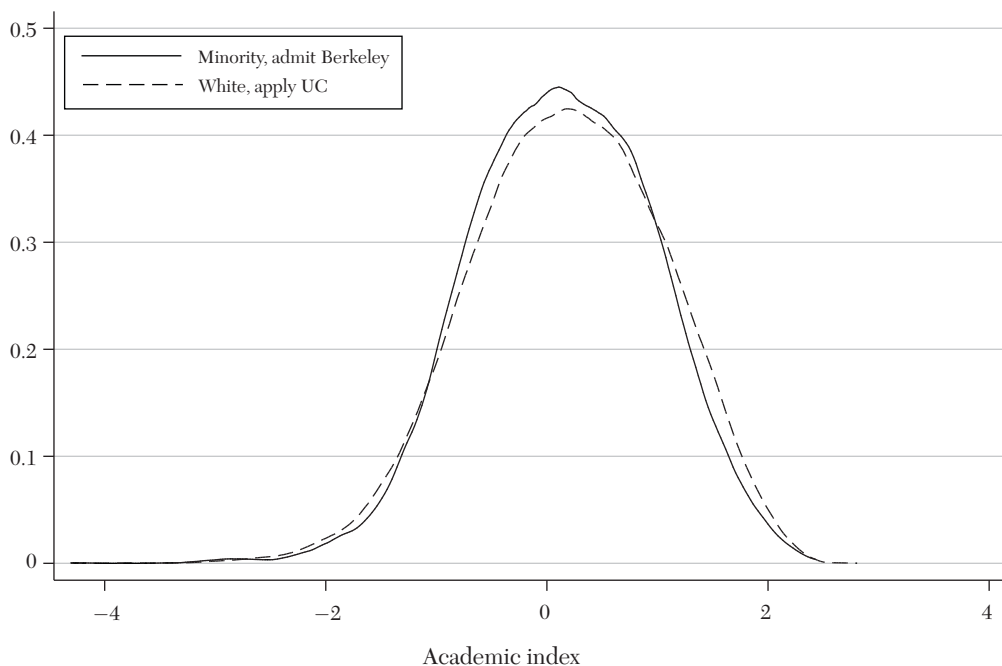


Figure 4. Distribution of Academic Indexes for Minority Berkeley Admits and White UC Applicants

*Notes:* Academic index is a weighted average of the student's SAT score and high school GPA and is normalized to be mean zero and standard deviation one for the population of applicants.

*Data source:* UCOP, years 1995–1997.

four UC schools, ranging from 40 percent at UC Berkeley to 21 percent at UC San Diego. Minority advantages were smaller at the next set of schools, likely for two reasons. First, there is less scope for racial preferences at the bottom set of schools. For example, for those who applied to UC Santa Cruz in this period, both whites and minorities had an over 80 percent chance of being admitted. Second, selection on unobservables is likely stronger at more elite schools as a result of minorities being aware of affirmative action. Those applying to the bottom schools probably were aware that their chances of admission were lower at UC Berkeley, despite racial preferences.

Dillon and Smith (2013) provide some additional information on how affirmative

action affects sorting using the National Longitudinal Study of Youth of 1997 (NLSY97) data. Their paper is focused on characterizing the extent of academic mismatch more generally, which they define as differences between student rank on the Armed Services Vocational Aptitude Battery (ASVAB) test given to NLSY97 respondents and college rank on an index of quality constructed from several measures of institutional characteristics. This analysis has the value of being nationally representative, although their small sample precludes them from examining mismatch along the college quality spectrum.

While the aim of Dillon and Smith (2013) is measuring and characterizing overall mismatch in higher education, they show some evidence that speaks directly